whom they would vote for in the general elections, gave us an insight into the political disposition of mass online audiences. Users could only vote once from a mobile number, results were masked until the final day to prevent rigging and the online poll was conducted in nine different languages.

Of the 8,44,646 people who voted, 73 per cent said they would vote for Modi as prime minister if general elections were to be held at that moment. Two other surveys—in December 2017 (over half a million respondents) and February 2019 (over 2,00,000 respondents)—yielded similar results: with over 70 per cent of those taking the survey in each case saying they would vote for Modi. He did win resoundingly in 2019, of course, but not by these margins.[33] The party's online ascendancy was far higher than its offline sway. As *India Today* magazine had concluded in a cover story in November 2013 after a similar e-poll of its own: 'The Internet is saffron.'[34] Such numbers fuel the assumption that somehow digital platforms are tailormade for groups like Hindu nationalists, who find it easier to dominate online with polarising messaging. The truth is somewhat more complicated, at least on Twitter.

To understand what was really happening, data scientist Rishabh Srivastava, journalist Sanjeev Singh and I set up a 'Twitter Listening Post' in early 2016. Over two and a half years—January 2016 to May 2019—we monitored seventy-five political accounts from across political parties and the messaging on a total of 4,76,827 tweets posted by them. We found a clear pattern where, from late 2017 onwards, Rahul Gandhi started making big strides. This started unfolding a little after the UP assembly election of February-March 2017 which the BJP had swept. While Modi's Twitter following was over five times that of Gandhi's—and he remained way ahead of Gandhi in terms of followers, reach and total posts (see Figures 7.4, 7.5 and 7.6)—on a per tweet basis, Rahul Gandhi started winning on engagement metrics over these two years. This was in spite of the fact that Gandhi put out only 1,497 tweets (between June 2017 and May 2019), as compared to 8,201 by Modi. Surprisingly, in average-per-tweet terms, he was beating Modi on Twitter in the number of retweets, likes and replies to his posts (see Figure 7.4). Modi's cumulative engagement metrics, however, remained way higher.